

Max Zhang

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Prompt: Write an argument within a specific rhetorical situation that explicates a current socio-economic problem.

We have all faced this panic before when talking to “cracked” friends or finding peer’s student profiles online. On the left, you see “cancer researcher,” and on the right, you see “founder of a non-profit.” Now that extra APUSH video you were watching because of genuine interest seems like a waste of time. That video has no award, no label, and no signal to colleges.

A few months ago, my brother suggested that I self-study Calculus over the summer.

I thought he was speaking a dead language. Instead, I studied for the American Mathematics Competition (AMC), where if you scored well enough, you would receive the title of “AIME Qualification.” Now that was something worthwhile, a signal of success. My friend and I put in hours per week, raising our average by over twenty points out of 150. We were excited.

Yesterday, the AMC cutoffs were released. Traditionally, the score distribution followed a logical curve with higher scores decreasing in quantity. This year, that graph looked to me like a crime scene. There were over 300 perfect scores in what was usually >20 , and the curve curved upwards. The cutoff rose from a historical average of 80-90, to an exclusive 100.5. ~~My friend and I felt robbed of a fair fight, and~~ It was clear that the exam’s security issues from previous years had evolved.

While the general consensus was cheating from a handful of individuals, we should honestly consider why our school’s culture pushes precarity and despair of being mediocre to such extents as to motivate immorality. This stems from our culture’s prioritization of signals to colleges and your labels of success over the learning process, learning the “math.” In essence, in society, a problem we see is when people attribute their self-worth to net-monetary wealth, but in high school, we see

Self-worth = sign value (your awards, labels, and accolades).

This may sound extreme, but on an honest level, this is the case for us, Bay Area HS students. We notice everywhere these “cancer researchers,” “olympiad medalists,” and “founders/presidents.” While people with these accolades are genuinely impressive, our societal precarity forces everyone to place having such labels above all else. Personally, I saw a Palo Alto student casually mentioning online that he would “pay \$20,000 for a research paper,” and in coding olympiads, people’s first thoughts to find a way of using ChatGPT. This is the problem. By only equating our worth or place in the school hierarchy to our sign-value, we forgo the process. Learning math is inefficient when I can just use test leaks, and any effort in school beyond an A is dead capital.

Today, as I write this essay, I hope we can both acknowledge this competition through precarity. Chasing status and labels are not inherently wrong, but it places us all in a situation where we can only put our efforts into tangible outcomes. Intrinsic motivation becomes dominated by external sign-value. As I see my classmates, I also feel the need to further this problem or risk drowning. Our positions are not solid unless we keep adding these labels, even if it means in an immoral way. “Join or die!”

If my brother asked me again to self-study Calculus, to follow intrinsic high-value desires, I would still hesitate, because we can't afford to drown.